



His Good Girl's Secret Nights

A Girlfriend Likes
a Double Life

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A girlfriend likes a double life

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The kitchen smelled like heaven at 6:47 in the morning.

I'd been awake since five, padding around in my linen apron, the cream one with the tiny embroidered strawberries that I'd thrifted last summer, waiting for the dough to finish its final proof. The sourdough starter had been my grandmother's once, passed down like an heirloom, and I'd kept it alive for three years now. I called her Mildred, though that was the starter, not my grandmother. My grandmother was named Dorothy, and she'd died when I was nineteen, but every time I fed Mildred her flour and water, I felt Dorothy's hands guiding mine.

The loaf was perfect. It came out golden-brown, with that signature ear splitting open along the score line, the crust crackling as it cooled on the wire rack. I photographed it seventeen times before I got the shot I wanted, morning light streaming through the window above the sink, the vintage mixing bowl just barely in frame, a dusting of flour across the butcher block that looked accidental but had taken me four tries to get right.

This was my life, the one I'd built and curated and cultivated like the sourdough itself.

From the spare bedroom that Ethan had converted into his home office, I could hear him on a call. He was saying something about server migration, or maybe it was a security patch, I never really understood what he did, just that it paid well and let him work from home three days a week. He'd moved into my apartment two years ago, after we'd been dating for five, and sometimes I still found myself surprised to hear his voice in the other room. It wasn't a bad kind of surprised, just surprised, like I'd forgotten he was there.

"The lag is unacceptable," he was saying, his voice muffled through the wall. "We need to escalate this before Monday."

I turned back to the bread and adjusted the angle of my phone. The lighting was doing something gorgeous to the crust, picking up amber and gold and a hint of that deep caramel where the sugars had caramelized. My

followers loved this, and the comments were always the same: goals, living my dream, you're so lucky. And I was lucky, because I knew I was.

After the bread cooled enough to slice, I cut the first piece for Ethan, spread it with the cultured butter I'd made last week, another project, another post, and arranged it on the blue ceramic plate we'd gotten at that artisan market in Vermont. He came out of the office just as I was photographing it, and he kissed my temple, his lips warm against my skin.

"Smells amazing, babe."

"Fresh from the oven."

"You spoil me." He took the plate, already chewing. "Hey, so I talked to the realtor yesterday."

"Oh?" My voice was light, still adjusting the exposure on my phone.

"That house on Maple Street, the one with the wraparound porch? She said the sellers are motivated, so we could probably get them down another fifteen thousand."

"That's great."

"Right? And the backyard, Ness, you could put a whole garden back there, raised beds, maybe some fruit trees. I was thinking about where we'd put the swing set."

I looked up from my phone. "Swing set?"

"For later, I mean. Down the road." He shrugged and took another bite of bread. "You know. When we're ready."

I smiled, because that was what I did. I smiled and I nodded and I felt the future unfurling in front of me like a map that someone else had drawn. House on Maple Street, raised beds, fruit trees, swing set. Ethan and Vanessa, just like he'd always planned, just like he'd been planning since junior year when he'd asked me to prom by spelling out my name in rose petals on my parents' lawn.

"I love you," I said.

"Love you too." He kissed me again, quick and familiar, and went back to his office with the plate. I heard the door close and the call resume.

I sat down at the kitchen table with my laptop, the bread cooling on the counter behind me, and started editing the photos. This was my favorite part, actually, the quiet alchemy of it, adjusting curves and shadows until the image matched the feeling I wanted to create, warmth, comfort, a life worth envying.

My blog was called *Hearthbound*, and I'd built it from nothing over the past four years. It had ten thousand followers now, a small sponsorship from a ceramic company, it was enough to feel real, enough to feel like mine.

I was adding a vignette to the best shot of the loaf when my phone buzzed with an email. It was a newsletter from the local arts council. I'd signed up months ago for a story about community pottery classes and had never unsubscribed. I almost deleted it without looking, but the subject line caught my eye:

THIS WEEKEND: Live Music at The Rusty Nail

I clicked through, though I wasn't sure why.

The email was sparse. There was a grainy photo of a stage I didn't recognize, dim and smoky-looking even in the still image, and a list of bands I'd never heard of, of course, Saturday night, doors at nine.

The Rusty Nail was a dive bar on the other side of downtown, the kind of place with sticky floors and neon beer signs that Ethan always said looked "sketchy."

I'd driven past it once, maybe twice, but I'd never been inside.

The headlining band was called Wolves at the Door. I didn't know why I was still reading, or why I saved the flyer to my photos instead of closing the email. I didn't know why, when Ethan called from the office asking if I wanted to watch that documentary about sustainable farming tonight, I hesitated before I answered.

"Sure," I said. "Sounds great."

But my thumb hovered over the screen and I kept looking at the photo of the stage, the empty microphone stands, the promise of something that had nothing to do with raised beds or swing sets or houses on Maple Street. I closed the laptop and sat there for a long moment before I realized the bread had gone cold.

The lie came out so easily it scared me. "Sarah wants to check out this new wine bar downtown," I said, pulling on my cardigan, the chunky oatmeal one I'd knitted myself last winter. "Girls' night. I'll be back by eleven."

Ethan didn't look up from his laptop. The documentary about sustainable farming played on the television behind him, unwatched, while a man in overalls explained something about crop rotation to an empty room.

"Have fun, babe. Tell Sarah I said hi."

"I will."

I didn't text Sarah, and I didn't even consider it. I just grabbed my keys and walked out the door. The whole drive across town I kept waiting for the guilt to hit, for the wrongness of it to stop me and make me turn around. But the only thing I felt was my heart beating too fast and my hands gripping the steering wheel like I was afraid I'd lose my nerve.

The Rusty Nail was worse than I'd imagined.

The parking lot was gravel and potholes, littered with cigarette butts and crushed beer cans. A neon sign buzzed and flickered above the door, half the letters burnt out, so it just read "RUS Y N L." The windows were blacked out, covered in peeling band stickers and a handwritten sign that said CASH ONLY.

I sat in my car for seven minutes, and I counted every one of them.

What are you doing, I asked myself. What are you doing here, Vanessa. Go home. Go home and watch the documentary and let Ethan rub your feet and stop being ridiculous.

But I got out of the car anyway.

Inside, the air was thick with smoke and sweat and darker, muskier, spilled beer, maybe, or decades of bad decisions soaked into the floorboards. The ceiling was low and stained. Christmas lights hung in tangles along the bar, half of them dead. The crowd was leather and ripped denim and combat boots, with tattoos crawling up necks and down arms. I stood there in my floral midi dress and hand-knitted cardigan like a lamb who'd wandered into a wolves' den.

Wolves at the Door, right.

A woman with a shaved head and a nose ring looked me up and down as I passed. A man with a beard down to his chest actually laughed, not meanly, exactly, but like I was a joke he hadn't expected.

I ordered a whiskey because I didn't know what else to order. The bartender, a tired-looking woman with sleeve tattoos of roses and skulls, raised an eyebrow but poured it without comment. I'd never had whiskey straight before, and it burned going down. I coughed, and the bearded man laughed again.

Go home, I thought. This isn't you. This has never been you.

But then the lights dimmed even further, and someone shouted something I couldn't make out, and the band took the stage.

There were four of them. The drummer had arms like tree trunks. The guitarist looked about sixteen, all lanky limbs and nervous energy. The singer had smeared eyeliner and a voice like broken glass.

And then there was the bassist.

He stood slightly apart from the others, half in shadow, and even before he played a single note I couldn't stop looking at him.

He was tall with dark hair that fell across his forehead and was pushed back carelessly. Tattoos covered both arms, disappearing under the sleeves of a black t-shirt that had seen better days. He had a sharp jaw and sharper cheekbones, and he held the bass like it was part of him, like it had grown there, and when his fingers found the strings. . . The sound hit me in the chest.

It wasn't pretty. It wasn't the kind of music I listened to, the soft acoustic folk I played while baking, the indie playlists I curated for lazy Sunday mornings. This was raw and loud and angry, the bass line a living thing that crawled under my skin and wrapped around my spine. The singer screamed something about burning down houses, about running from ghosts, and the bassist, Dante, the flyer had said his name was Dante, moved like he was somewhere else entirely, eyes half-closed, lost in it.

I forgot about my whiskey. I forgot about the smoke and the sticky floor and the people around me. I forgot about Ethan and Maple Street and raised beds and swing sets. For twenty minutes, maybe thirty, I just watched him.

I watched the way his fingers moved. I watched the way his jaw tightened when he hit a particularly brutal riff. I watched the way he sometimes looked up, scanning the crowd with dark eyes, and I'd look away fast, afraid he'd see me staring, and afraid he wouldn't.

He was nothing like Ethan. Ethan ironed his shirts on Sunday nights. Ethan had a five-year plan and a ten-year plan and a retirement account he'd started at twenty-two. Ethan was safe and good and exactly what my mother had always wanted for me.

This man looked like he'd never planned anything in his life, like he woke up each day and let the wind take him, like he'd burn the map before he'd follow it.

The set ended too soon.

The crowd cheered and whistled, and the band took a bow, more of a collective shrug, and then they were dispersing, with the drummer heading

for the back room and the singer leaning down to talk to someone in the front row.

And then there was the bassist.

Dante.

He stepped off the stage and cut through the crowd like water. I realized too late that he was walking straight toward me, not past me, not around me. Toward me. His eyes were locked on mine. They were darker up close, deep brown with flecks, and I couldn't look away, couldn't move, couldn't remember how to breathe.

He stopped right in front of me, close enough that I could smell him, cigarettes and sweat, cedar maybe, or sandalwood, warm and woody that made my head swim.

He leaned against the bar, one arm brushing mine, and tilted his head. A smile played at the corner of his mouth, not quite friendly and not quite anything.

"Why's a girl like you here alone?"

His voice was low, rough from singing backup, and the question landed somewhere in the center of my chest and stayed there, heavy.

I opened my mouth, but nothing came out.

I'm not alone, I should have said. My boyfriend's at home. I have a boyfriend. I'm just here to, I was curious about, I saw a flyer and...

But I couldn't form the words. I couldn't form any words. I just stood there holding the whiskey I'd barely touched, in my ridiculous floral dress, and looked up at him like he'd asked me something much more complicated than he had, like he'd asked me who I was, and like I didn't know the answer.

"I, I just like supporting local music," I managed finally, the words coming out thin and ridiculous. "The arts council newsletter. There was a flyer."

He laughed, not meanly, but like I'd said something that genuinely amused him. "The arts council."

"They send emails."

"And you read them."

"Sometimes." I was gripping my whiskey glass so hard I thought it might shatter. "When I'm bored."

"You bored a lot?" He was still too close, and I could see a scar through his left eyebrow, a thin white line that split the dark hair. "In your little

life?"

"My life isn't little."

"No?" He reached past me for the bartender's attention, his arm brushing mine, and I forgot how to breathe for a second. "Whiskey. Neat. And another for..." He looked at me, waiting.

"Vanessa."

"Vanessa." He said it slowly, like he was tasting it. "Pretty name. Old-fashioned."

"It was my grandmother's."

"Of course it was."

The bartender set down two glasses, and Dante picked his up, took a long swallow, and watched me over the rim. His eyes were impossible, dark and depthless and slightly mocking, like he could see straight through my floral dress and hand-knitted cardigan to something underneath I didn't even know was there.

"So what do you do, Vanessa-with-the-grandmother's-name? When you're not reading arts council newsletters?"

"I have a blog." It sounded even more ridiculous out loud, here, in this place. "A lifestyle blog. Baking and crafts and..."

"Cute."

"It's a real job."

"I didn't say it wasn't." There was that almost-smile again. "Let me guess. Sourdough, linen napkins. Everything photographed in golden hour."

I stared at him. "How did you..."

"You've got flour under your fingernails."

I looked down, and he was right. There was a thin line of white in the crease of my thumbnail, evidence of this morning's loaf that I'd missed when I washed my hands.

"Observant," I said.

"Comes with the territory." He finished his whiskey and set the glass down hard. "You have a boyfriend, Vanessa?"

The question hit me like cold water. "I, yes. Why?"

"Because you're here alone on a Saturday night, in a bar you've clearly never been to, looking at me like..." He stopped and tilted his head. "Like you're hungry for something you can't get at home."

"That's not, I'm not..."

"Okay."

"I should go."

"Probably."

But I didn't move and he didn't move, and the space between us felt like it was vibrating, like the bass line was still thrumming through the floor, through my bones, through the part of me that had followed a flyer to a dive bar and lied to Ethan without a second thought.

"What's his name?" Dante asked. "The boyfriend."

"Ethan."

"Ethan." He said it the way he'd said my name, slow and deliberate, but with something sharper underneath. "And what does Ethan do?"

"He works in IT."

"Of course he does." Dante pulled a Sharpie from his back pocket, just had one there, apparently, like it was normal, and reached for my hand before I could stop him. His fingers were calloused and warm, wrapping around my wrist and turning my palm up. "Ethan in IT. With his girl who bakes sourdough and reads arts council newsletters."

"What are you doing?"

He didn't answer, and instead just uncapped the marker with his teeth and wrote on my palm, the felt tip dragging across my skin and leaving black numbers in its wake. His handwriting was messy, almost illegible.

"When you figure out what you came here looking for," he said, capping the pen while still holding my wrist, "call me."

"I wasn't looking for..."

"Yeah." He let go of my hand and stepped back. The absence of his heat felt like a loss. "You were."

And then he was gone, disappearing into the back room, and I was left standing at the bar with a number on my palm and my heart trying to beat its way out of my chest.

I didn't wash my hand when I got home.

Ethan was asleep, the documentary long over, and the apartment was quiet and dark. I stood in the bathroom with the door locked and stared at the numbers on my skin, and I copied them in a secret place. Then I forgot about the bar and the band and the man who looked at me like he knew something I didn't.

For three days, I didn't call.

I baked and photographed and wrote a post about the perfect autumn tablescape, complete with mini pumpkins and vintage candlesticks. Ethan

talked about the house on Maple Street, about mortgage rates, about the three bedrooms with the good school district, and I smiled and nodded and felt the ghost of Sharpie on my palm even though I'd scrubbed it off in the shower, scrubbed until my skin was raw and pink.

On Thursday, Ethan left for a conference in Chicago for two nights. He kissed me at the door, told me to miss him, told me he'd call before bed.

I waited until his Uber pulled away. Then I found the scrap of paper where I'd copied the number, just in case, I'd told myself, just so I'd have it, and I typed out a text before I could stop myself.

It's Vanessa. From the bar.

The reply came in under a minute.

Took you long enough. Address?

I hesitated, of course. But then I sent it to him. I don't know what I was thinking.

He showed up at nine in another black t-shirt, smelling like cigarettes and the ghost of whiskey. I'd changed three times before settling on jeans and a blouse, trying to look like I hadn't thought about it, like this was casual, like I invited strange men to my apartment while my boyfriend was out of town all the time.

"Nice place," he said, not looking at it, just looking at me.

"Do you want something to drink? I have wine, or..."

"No."

He crossed the room in three steps and kissed me.

It wasn't like Ethan kissing me. Ethan kissed me like I was something precious, something breakable, soft and slow and careful. Dante kissed me like he was trying to take something, his hand curling in my hair, pulling my head back, his teeth catching my bottom lip hard enough to sting.

I made a sound I didn't recognize.

"That's what I thought," he murmured against my mouth. "That's what you came looking for."

"I didn't..."

His other hand found my hip, fingers digging in. "You wanted something that nice boy can't give you, something that scares you a little."

"I'm not scared."

"No?" He pulled back just enough to look at me, his eyes dark and knowing. "Then why are you shaking?"

I was shaking. I hadn't noticed until he said it, but my whole body was trembling, not from fear, from something coiled up inside me for years, maybe forever, something I'd buried under sourdough starters and linen napkins and a life that looked perfect in photographs.

"Because I want this," I heard myself say. "And I know I shouldn't."

"But you do."

"Yes."

He smiled, slow and dangerous, and walked me backward toward the bedroom.

I'd never been touched like that.

Ethan made love to me in the dark, under the covers, always gentle, always asking if I was okay, if this was good, if I was comfortable. He treated my body like something fragile, and I'd always thought that was what I wanted, tenderness, care, respect.

Dante didn't ask.

He pushed me onto the bed and stood over me for a moment, just looking, and I felt more naked under his gaze than I ever had without clothes. Then he was on me, pulling at my blouse, and the sound of buttons scattering across the hardwood should have horrified me but instead it sent a jolt straight through my core, hot and electric.

"I'm going to have to explain that," I gasped. "The buttons..."

"So lie." His mouth found my neck, biting down just below my jaw, hard enough to bruise. "You're good at that."

I should have been angry, and I should have pushed him off and told him to leave. Instead I arched up into him, my fingers finding his shoulders, his back, the muscles that shifted under his skin as he unhooked my bra with one hand and pulled it away.

"Tell me to stop," he said against my collarbone. "If you want me to stop."

"I don't."

"No."

He took his time, moving slower than I expected, his mouth tracing a path down my stomach while his hands worked at my jeans. I lifted my hips to help him, some part of my brain still functioning, still trying to be useful, accommodating, the good girl I'd always been.

I felt his breath on my inner thigh. I felt his fingers hooking into my underwear and dragging them down. I felt exposed in a way I never had

before, spread open in my own bedroom in the lamplight while a man I barely knew looked at me like I was something to be devoured.

When his mouth found me, I cried out, too loud. I thought, the neighbors might hear, but I couldn't stop myself. He licked into me slow and lightly, one hand pressing flat on my stomach to hold me down when I tried to move, when I tried to chase the sensation. His other hand joined his mouth, two fingers sliding inside me, curling, finding a spot Ethan had never found or maybe never looked for.

"Oh god, oh..."

"Yeah" He pulled back just enough to speak, his breath hot against me. "I like to hear it."

"I can't, it's too..."

"You can." Another curl of his fingers, his tongue circling my clit. "Let it go."

I heard myself making sounds I'd never made, desperate and raw and utterly unlike the quiet, controlled girl who photographed bread in golden hour. Dante didn't stop, didn't ease up, and just worked me through it until I was shaking and over-sensitized and pulling at his hair, trying to push him away.

He let me and pulled back. He wiped his mouth with the back of his hand, watched me with those dark, knowing eyes.

"Ethan ever make you come like that?"

I couldn't answer and could barely breathe.

"That's what I thought."

He stood up and stripped off his shirt. I saw the tattoos fully for the first time, a wolf's head on his chest, vines and thorns crawling up his ribs, words in a language I didn't recognize along his collarbone. His body was lean and hard, nothing like Ethan's softness, and when he unbuckled his belt I felt a fresh wave of want pulse through me even though I'd just come, even though I was still trembling from it.

"You sure about this?" he asked, shoving his jeans down. "Last chance to go back to your nice little life."

I sat up and reached for him. I wrapped my fingers around him and watched his jaw tighten, his eyes go half-lidded.

"I'm sure."

He pushed me back down and hooked my knees over his forearms and lined himself up.

"Tell me if it's too much."

"It won't be."

"Look at you go."

He pushed inside me in one long stroke, and I gasped at the stretch of it, the fullness. He was bigger than Ethan, and he didn't give me time to adjust, just pulled back and thrust in again, setting a rhythm that was hard and fast and exactly what I hadn't known I needed.

"This what you came for?" He was braced over me, forearms on either side of my head, his face inches from mine. "This what you dreamed about in your pretty little kitchen?"

"Yes..."

"Say it louder."

"Yes."

He shifted his angle, drove deeper, and I cried out again. One of his hands found my throat, not squeezing, just resting there, a pressure that made everything more intense, more immediate. I could feel my own pulse against his palm.

"You're going to think about this," he said, his voice low and rough. "Every time he touches you. Every time he kisses you goodnight. You're going to think about me inside you."

"I know."

"And you're going to call me again."

"I..."

"Say it."

"I'm going to call you again."

He smiled, dark and satisfied, and his hand tightened on my throat as he thrust harder, faster, his hips snapping against mine. I was climbing again, impossible as it seemed, the pressure building low in my stomach, my whole body coiling toward something,

"Come for me," he said. "Now."

I did, like he'd commanded it, like my body belonged to him now, not to me, not to Ethan, just to this man who'd seen through me from the first moment, who'd known what I wanted before I did.

He followed a moment later, burying himself deep, groaning against my neck. For a long moment we stayed like that, tangled together, breathing hard.

Then he pulled out and rolled onto his back beside me and stared at the ceiling.

"I gotta go," he said eventually.

I thought about Ethan in Chicago, the conference, his call before bed, the life we were building, the house on Maple Street, the swing set in the backyard.

"You should go," I said.

He nodded and didn't seem offended. He just got up and dressed, found his shirt on the floor, and pulled it over his head. At the bedroom door, he paused.

"You know where to find me, Vanessa."

"I know."

He left, and I heard the front door open and close, and the apartment went quiet.

I lay there in the tangled sheets that smelled like him, like cigarettes and cedar and sex, and I waited for the guilt to come.

But it didn't.

The eggs were wrong.

Ethan had made them scrambled, the way he always did when he was trying to be sweet, but it was too much butter, cooked too long, rubbery in that specific way that I'd learned to smile through years ago. He'd arranged them on the blue ceramic plate with toast cut into triangles and a handful of strawberries, and he'd put a little daisy from the grocery store bouquet in a juice glass beside my coffee.

"Surprise," he said, grinning. "I got an earlier flight. Wanted to wake up with my girl."

I was wearing his old college sweatshirt, pulled down over my thighs, hiding the bruise on my hip where Dante's fingers had dug in. There was another mark on my neck, just below my jaw, I'd seen it in the bathroom mirror when I woke up and my stomach had dropped. But I'd covered it with concealer, layered thick, and prayed Ethan wouldn't look too closely.

He didn't. He never did.

"This is so sweet," I said, and my voice sounded normal. That was the worst part. How normal I sounded. "You didn't have to do this."

"I wanted to." He kissed my forehead, then sat across from me at the little kitchen table, pulling up his laptop. "Okay, so while I was at the conference, I saved like six new listings. There's this one on Birch Street

that just came on the market, fixer-upper, but the bones are incredible. And the backyard, Ness. You have to see this backyard."

I took a bite of the rubbery eggs and nodded.

My body ached in places I'd never ached before, not painfully, or not just painfully. A deep soreness that reminded me, with every shift in my chair, of exactly what had happened in our bed last night, Dante's hands, Dante's mouth, Dante's voice in my ear, telling me I'd think about him every time Ethan touched me.

He was right.

Ethan turned the laptop toward me. A cheerful real estate listing filled the screen, white siding, black shutters, a yard that went on forever. "See? And there's already a shed in the back. I could convert it into a workshop. Or you could use it for your blog stuff, like a little studio."

"It's beautiful."

"Right? And it's only fifteen minutes from my office. Twenty in traffic."

"Perfect."

"I knew you'd love it." He reached across the table and squeezed my hand. His palm was soft. Uncalloused. "I can call the realtor Monday, see if we can get a showing this week."

"Sure."

"Ness." He tilted his head, studying me with those earnest blue eyes. "You okay? You seem tired."

"Just didn't sleep well." I smiled, easy and practiced. "Missed you."

"Aw, babe." He squeezed my hand again. "I missed you too. It was so weird sleeping without you. The hotel bed was huge and cold and I just kept reaching over and you weren't there."

I was here, I thought. I was here, in our bed, with someone else inside me.

"I know the feeling," I said.

After breakfast, Ethan went to shower, and I sat at the table with my cold coffee and looked at the remnants of his attempt at romance. The sad eggs. The grocery store daisy. The toast triangles I'd eaten three bites of.

I picked up my phone.

The camera app opened smooth and familiar, and I arranged the plate just so, catching the morning light, making sure the daisy was in frame. I took twelve shots, adjusted the angle, took eight more, found the one where everything looked warm and golden and perfect, where you couldn't tell the

eggs were overcooked, where the moment looked like something worth wanting.

I opened Instagram and typed out a caption.

When he comes home early just to make you breakfast ❖❖❖❖ *This man. I don't deserve him.*

I stared at the words for a long moment, then I posted it.

The likes started rolling in immediately. *Goals. So sweet. Where did you find him, I need one.* I watched the numbers climb and felt nothing, less than nothing. A hollow space where something used to be.

I was wiping down the counter when my phone buzzed with an unknown number.

I glanced toward the bathroom. The shower was still running. Ethan was singing something off-key, muffled by the water and the closed door.

I opened the message. *Next show is Thursday.*

No greeting, no name. Just five words that made my whole body flush hot.

I should delete it and block the number and forget any of this ever happened. I should go back to my real life, the one I'd built so carefully, the one that looked so beautiful in photographs.

My thumb hovered over the screen. The shower turned off. I typed back, fast: *What time?*

The response came in seconds: *9. Same place. Wear something I can take off easy.*

"Ness?" Ethan's voice, from the hallway. "Have you seen my blue shirt? The one with the stripes?"

"Check the spare closet," I called back. "Left side."

I looked at the phone in my hand. The message thread that would ruin everything if anyone saw it.

I opened my contacts, created a new entry.

Sarahh. Purposefully misspelled, oops.

I saved the number, deleted the thread, set the phone face-down on the counter just as Ethan emerged from the hallway, toweling his hair, grinning at me like I was the best thing he'd ever seen.

"Found it," he said, holding up the blue striped shirt. "You're the best."

"I know," I said.

He laughed and came over to kiss me, and I let him, but I thought about Thursday.

It came like a fever. I told Ethan I was going to a book club meeting, Sarah's book club, naturally, a lie building on a lie, and I wore the black dress I'd bought three years ago for a friend's bachelorette party and never worn again. It was too short. Too tight, nothing like me.

I looked in the mirror before I left and didn't recognize myself.

Dante found me before the set even started, pulled me into the back hallway behind the stage, pressed me against the wall between a stack of broken amplifiers and a fire exit that probably hadn't worked in years.

"You came," he said.

"I said I would."

"Lots of people say things."

His mouth found my neck, my collarbone, the spot just above the neckline of the dress that would be visible if he marked me there. He bit down anyway. I gasped and didn't push him away.

After the show, he took me to his apartment, a studio above a laundromat, mattress on the floor, ashtrays overflowing, bass guitars lined up against the wall like soldiers. He undressed me slowly that time, taking inventory.

"Bruise," he said, tracing the mark on my hip. "From last time?"

"Yes."

"Does he notice?"

"He doesn't look."

Something flickered in Dante's eyes, satisfaction, maybe. Or something darker. "His loss."

He pulled me over him, and moved me around so that I was face down between his legs, over him. He wouldn't have known that I hadn't done that before, he must have assumed. But when his mouth came up between my legs, when his tongue slipped down between my folds, I was powerless to stop grabbing it, squeezing it.

He made me shudder. I kissed it and he pushed up. I circled the top with my mouth, and he groaned with self-satisfied pleasure. I laid my tongue out and licked. He pushed his tongue into me and I sank my mouth down over as much of him as I could.

I rode him, leaning back with my hands on his shins, his hands all over my chest. He sank into me with my knees hooked high over his shoulders. He took me from behind and slapped my ass too hard. I whimpered at him,

I twisted around to glare at him, but he jolted me so hard, so relentlessly, I could not hold back.

Nor could he when I convulsed, when I spasmed around him, when I went down on my stomach under him, lifting my hips and twisting his sheets in my fist, it was so much.

He kept me there until two in the morning. I drove home with the windows down, letting the cold air clear my head, and crawled into bed beside Ethan, who didn't stir.

Saturday morning, I baked cinnamon rolls from scratch, photographed them with fall leaves and a vintage rolling pin. Ethan ate four and called me his favorite person in the world.

@hearthbound: Lazy Saturday mornings with my love  Recipe link in bio!

Saturday night, I told him I was going to Sarah's birthday dinner.

I let Dante fuck me in his car in the parking lot behind The Rusty Nail, my dress hiked up around my waist, fogging the windows like teenagers, my hand slapping the window and sliding down the condensation. He pulled my hair so hard my eyes watered. I came twice before he did.

Sunday, Ethan and I looked at houses online. He made a spreadsheet comparing school districts.

The compartmentalization became easier than I expected. I learned the rhythms of both lives, how they fit together like puzzle pieces that shouldn't connect but somehow did. Monday through Wednesday, I was Vanessa, the blogger, the baker, the good girlfriend. I tested recipes. I responded to brand partnership emails. I planned content calendars and edited photos until every image glowed with warmth I didn't feel.

Thursday was Dante's.

I stopped pretending I was going to the show for the music. I sat at the bar until the set ended, "the bassist's chic," and then I was his for as long as he wanted me. Sometimes at his apartment, sometimes in the alley behind the venue, my back against cold brick, his hand over my mouth to keep me quiet. Once, in the single-stall bathroom I'd imagined that first night, finally, filthy and frantic and over in minutes.

"You're getting bold," he said that night, zipping his jeans while I tried to fix my hair in the grimy mirror.

"What do you mean?" I grinned.

"First time, you could barely say your own name. Now look at you."

I looked” smeared lipstick, flushed cheeks, mascara smudged. A woman I was still learning about apparently.

"Is that bad?"

"It's fucking hot is what it is."

Friday I recovered, showered three times, made sure every mark was covered or faded, and practiced my smile in the mirror until it looked real again.

Saturday morning, I made croissants. They took two days of prep, the laminating, the folding, the careful layers of butter and dough, and they came out golden and flaky and perfect. Ethan took a bite and actually moaned.

"How are you so good at this?" he asked.

"Practice."

@hearthbound: Two days of work for five minutes of heaven ✨ Worth every second.

Saturday night was Sarah's wine tasting event.

Dante bent me over his kitchen counter and told me to count. I lost track somewhere around seven. He didn't let me come until I started over.

Sunday, Ethan suggested we adopt a dog. Start practicing, he said, for when we have kids.

I started to forget which version of myself was real.

Thursday, Dante asked me why I even stayed with Ethan. We were lying naked on his mattress, sharing a cigarette I didn't really smoke, staring at the water-stained ceiling.

"Because I love him," I said.

"Do you?"

"Of course."

"Then why are you here?"

I didn't answer and he didn't push. That was the thing about Dante, he never pushed for more than I was willing to give. He took what I offered and he didn't ask questions and he never, not once, suggested I leave Ethan for him. Like this was all he wanted, like I was just another distraction, another girl in a black dress who wandered into his bar.

And maybe I was. It was a life without expectations, unlike the other one.

Saturday morning, I made a Dutch baby pancake, showered in powdered sugar and fresh berries. Ethan fed me a bite across the table and called me

his future wife.

I froze.

He didn't notice. He was already reaching for his phone, pulling up another house listing. This one had a breakfast nook.

@hearthbound: Sunday pancakes with my forever person 
(Yes, I know it's Saturday. We make our own rules.)

Saturday night it was Sarah's housewarming party.

Dante pulled me into the alley before I even made it inside the bar. He pushed me to my knees on the dirty pavement and I opened without being asked. He opened his fly, took his cock out, and he held my head and fucked my mouth. When he finished, he pulled me up by the hair and kissed me, hard and filthy.

"You're ruining me," I said, wiping my chin with the back of my hand. I didn't swallow all of him, but I was getting there.

"Yeah."

Sunday came.

I was sitting at the kitchen table, editing photos from the morning's shoot, a spread of autumn recipes, butternut squash soup and apple crisp and mulled wine, when Ethan sat down across from me. His hands were clasped on the table. His knee was bouncing.

"Ness."

I looked up. "Yeah?"

"Need to talk."

Something in my chest seized. He knew. He'd found out somehow, a text I forgot to delete, a mark I'd missed, the smell of cigarettes in my hair,

"About what?" My voice was steady. I was proud of that at least.

"So." He took a breath, smiled nervously. "I talked to my mom this week."

Not what I expected.

"Okay?"

"And she, well, we've been talking about the house hunt, and the future, and..." He ran a hand through his hair, the way he always did when he was working up to something. "She wants to take us ring shopping, next weekend. At that place in the city where my dad got her engagement ring."

My whole body went cold.

"Ethan..."

"I know, I know, we haven't officially talked about this." He reached across the table and took my hands. His palms were sweating. "But Ness, I've been ready for years. Since high school. Since the first time you smiled at me in AP English and I knew, I just knew, you were it for me."

I couldn't speak.

"I'm not proposing right now," he said quickly. "That would be, I mean, I want it to be special, perfect. The way you deserve. But I want you to know that I'm ready. Whenever you are. I'm ready to spend the rest of my life with you."

His eyes were so blue, so earnest, so full of love for a woman who didn't exist anymore.

"Ethan," I said again.

"You don't have to answer right now. I just wanted you to know." He squeezed my hands. "I love you, Vanessa. I've always loved you. I always will."

In my pocket, my phone buzzed.

I knew without looking who it was.

The jewelry store smelled like old money and more expectations.

Ethan's mother, Patricia, had booked an appointment three weeks in advance. "You can't just walk into Harrington's," she'd explained on the phone, as if I'd suggested something vulgar. "They need time to prepare the family pieces."

Family pieces, because of course the Hartleys had heirloom rings passed down through generations, stored in velvet boxes in bank vaults, waiting for the next acceptable bride.

"Now, this one was my grandmother's," Patricia said, sliding a platinum band across the glass counter. The diamond was enormous, two carats, maybe more, flanked by sapphires that caught the light and threw blue shadows across my hands. "She wore it for sixty-three years. Can you imagine? Sixty-three years with the same man."

"That's beautiful," I said.

Ethan squeezed my shoulder. "Mom, we're just looking today, no pressure."

"Of course, sweetheart. No pressure at all." Patricia smiled at me, the kind of smile that was all teeth and no warmth. "I just want Vanessa to see what's available. To understand what she's becoming part of."

I understood perfectly.

The saleswoman, Margot, according to her tasteful name tag, brought out another tray, more rings, more history, more weight.

"This setting is from 1923," Margot explained, lifting a ring with an art deco band, geometric and elegant. "The center stone was added in 1952, when Mr. Hartley's great-uncle proposed to his wife in Paris."

"Paris," I repeated, because something was expected of me.

"They were married for forty-one years," Patricia added. "She never took it off, not once, not even when she was gardening."

Ethan laughed. "Mom, Vanessa's not really the gardening type."

"I garden," I said, too quickly. "I have herbs. On the windowsill."

"Of course you do, dear."

I tried on seven rings. Each one felt heavier than the last, pressing into my finger like a brand. Ethan watched with shining eyes as I held my hand up to the light, turning it this way and that, performing the ritual of a woman falling in love with her future.

"What do you think?" he asked. "Any favorites?"

I looked down at the ring currently on my finger, his great-grandmother's, apparently, with a center stone the color of old ice. It fit perfectly. Of course it did.

"They're all so beautiful," I said. "It's hard to choose."

"You don't have to choose today," Ethan said.

"But you should start thinking," Patricia added. "Spring weddings book up quickly. If you're considering May or June, we'll need to secure a venue by January."

"Mom..."

"I'm just being practical, Ethan."

I slid the ring off my finger, handed it back to Margot, smiled the smile I'd been perfecting for years.

"Could we maybe come back?" I asked. "Once I've had time to think about which setting speaks to me?"

Patricia's eyes flickered with something, disappointment, calculation, but she nodded graciously. "Of course. Margot, could you hold these pieces for us? I'd hate for them to go to another family while Vanessa makes up her mind."

"Absolutely, Mrs. Hartley."

On the drive home, Ethan held my hand across the console. "Sorry about my mom," he said. "She can be a lot."

"She's fine."

"She just really likes you. She's been waiting for this since we started dating." He glanced at me, grinning. "Honestly, I think she likes you more than she likes me."

"That's not true."

"It's a little true." He lifted my hand to his lips, kissed my knuckles. "I'm just glad you're taking this seriously. I know it's a lot, the rings, the family stuff. But it means so much to me that you're doing this."

"Of course," I said.

"I love you, Ness. So much."

"I love you too."

The words came out smooth and easy, like they always did, like they didn't taste like ash in my mouth.

That night, Ethan fell asleep by ten, exhausted from the day of shopping, and I lay beside him in the dark, staring at the ceiling, feeling the phantom weight of rings I hadn't chosen yet.

My phone buzzed on the nightstand.

Come over.

Two words, no punctuation, no please. Dante never said please.

I should have rolled over and curled into Ethan's warmth and forget about the man across town who'd taken up residence somewhere beneath my skin. I should be the woman who tried on family heirlooms and talked about spring weddings and meant it.

But I got out of bed.

I dressed in the dark, jeans, a sweater, nothing special. I wasn't performing for Dante the way I performed for everyone else. He'd seen me ruined and raw and desperate. There was nothing left to pretend.

The drive to his apartment took twenty-three minutes. I counted every one.

His building was worse than I remembered.

The laundromat downstairs was closed, security gate pulled down, but the fluorescent lights still hummed behind it, casting a sickly glow through the dirty windows. I climbed the stairs to the second floor, no elevator, peeling wallpaper, the smell of mildew and old cigarettes, and knocked twice.

Dante opened the door shirtless.

"Took you long enough."

"I had to wait until he was asleep."

He stepped aside to let me in. I'd been here before, but always in the dark, always frantic, barely registering anything beyond his hands and his mouth and the mattress on the floor. Now I stood in his doorway and actually looked.

It was chaos.

Records everywhere, stacked against walls, piled on the floor, spilling out of milk crates that served as furniture, clothes draped over a chair that might have been vintage or might have been garbage. An ashtray overflowing on the windowsill. Empty bottles of whiskey lined up on the counter like trophies.

And his bass guitars, four of them, leaning against the far wall beside a battered amp covered in stickers.

"Nice place," I said.

"You're a terrible liar."

"I'm an excellent liar. That's the problem."

He crossed the room and kissed me, one hand tangling in my hair, pulling my head back the way he knew I liked. I opened for him without thinking, my body already responding, already forgetting everything else.

"How was ring shopping?" he murmured against my mouth.

I froze.

He pulled back, studying my face. "Yeah, I figured. You've got that look."

"What look?"

"The one where you're wondering how the fuck you ended up here."

"I know how I ended up here."

"Do you?" He traced a finger along my jaw, down my throat, stopping at the collar of my sweater. "Because from where I'm standing, you're about to marry some guy who bores you to death, and you're in my apartment at eleven on a Saturday night looking for something he can't give you."

"That's not..."

"It's not a judgment." He shrugged, stepping back. "I don't care what you do with your life, Vanessa. But don't lie to yourself about why you're here."

"Then why am I here?"

He smiled, slow and knowing, and pulled his belt free with a sound that made my stomach clench.

"Because you're starving," he said. "And he feeds you crumbs."

He took me apart slowly that night.

Not the frantic, rough coupling of the past few weeks, though there was that too, later, but something more planned, more devastating.

He laid me out on his mattress, the sheets tangled, and he stripped me piece by piece, taking his time with each layer. Every time I reached for him, tried to speed things up, he pushed my hands away.

"No," he said. "Tonight you just take."

"I don't..."

"You don't know how. I know." He pressed a kiss to the inside of my wrist, then pinned it above my head. "That's why I'm teaching you."

He spent what felt like hours on my body, mapping it with his mouth and his hands, finding places I didn't know were sensitive, the backs of my knees, the dip of my waist, the spot just below my ear that made me gasp when he bit down.

By the time he finally settled between my thighs, I was shaking.

"Dante..."

"Not yet."

He licked me slow and thoroughly, building me up and backing off, again and again, until I was begging with words I'd never said before, desperate and shameless. He laughed against me, the vibration making me cry out, and then he gave me what I needed, his tongue working in circles while two fingers curled inside me.

I shattered.

But he didn't stop.

"Again," he said, and I shook my head, overstimulated, but he held me down with one hand splayed across my stomach and kept going, relentless, until the second orgasm crashed through me so hard my vision went white.

"Such a good girl."

The words shouldn't have affected me. They did anyway.

He moved up my body, kissing a path along my stomach, my ribs, the space between my breasts. When he reached my mouth, he kissed me deep, letting me taste myself on his tongue.

"Tell me what you want," he said.

"You."

"Be specific."

I pulled him closer, wrapped my legs around his waist, felt him hard and hot against my thigh. "I want you inside me."

"Ask nicely, baby."

"Please." The word came out broken. "Please, Dante, fuck me."

He pushed inside me in one long stroke, and I arched up hard off the mattress, my fingers digging into his shoulders hard enough to leave marks. He set a punishing rhythm immediately, none of the slow buildup of before, just raw and hard and exactly what I needed.

"Look at me," he said, and I did, meeting his dark eyes as he drove into me. "You think about this when you're with him?"

"Yes."

"Think about my cock when he's inside you?"

"Yes..."

"Wish it was me?"

"Always..." I was close again, impossibly, the pressure building. "Dante, I'm..."

"I know." He shifted his angle, hitting something deep. "Come for me."

It was harder than before, my whole body clenching around him in wave after wave. He groaned and followed, burying himself deep, and for a long moment we stayed like that, tangled together, breathing hard.

Then he pulled out and rolled onto his back.

"Give me ten minutes," he said.

The second time was slower, me on top, his hands guiding my hips while he watched me move with those heavy-lidded eyes. He talked through it, filthy things, telling me how good I looked riding him, how tight I was, how he thought about me when he was on stage. Every word wound me tighter until I came with his thumb on my clit and his name on my lips.

The third time was against the wall, my legs wrapped around him, his hand over my mouth to muffle my cries because the walls were thin and his neighbors already hated him. It was fast and brutal and I left scratches down his back that he'd feel for days.

After, we lay on the mattress in the dark, passing a cigarette back and forth. The only light came from the streetlamp outside, filtering through his dirty window, casting everything in orange and shadow.

"You should go," he said eventually. "Before the sun comes up."

"I know."

"He'll notice if you're not there in the morning."

"I know."

But I didn't move, not yet.

"What time is it?" I asked.

He checked his phone. "Almost three."

Three in the morning, ring shopping at noon, engaged by nightfall, at least in Patricia's mind, and now here, naked and spent in a bassist's unmade bed, smelling like cigarettes and sex.

"I should go," I said.

"Yeah."

I got dressed slowly, aware of his eyes on me, cataloging every movement. At the door, I paused.

"Thursday?" I asked.

"I'll be there."

The drive home was quiet.

I rolled the windows down again, letting the cold air wash over me, trying to clear the fog from my head. The streets were empty at this hour, just me and the occasional streetlight, the city sleeping while I drove through it like a ghost.

I thought about the rings.

The art deco band, the sapphire setting, sixty-three years with the same man. Patricia's expectations and Ethan's earnest eyes and the spring wedding that was already taking shape in everyone's minds but mine.

Then I thought about Dante.

His hands on my throat, his voice in my ear, the way he looked at me like he could see straight through to the parts I'd been hiding, even from myself.

I was going to say yes.

I knew it with sudden, terrible clarity. I was going to go back to Harrington's and try on the rings again and let Patricia plan her spring wedding and stand at the altar in white while Ethan looked at me like I was everything good in the world.

I was going to marry him.

And I was never going to stop going to Thursday shows either.

I pulled into my driveway at 3:47 a.m. The house was dark. Ethan was still sleeping.

I sat in the car for a long moment, hands on the steering wheel, staring at nothing.

I had said yes to a ring without ever saying no to Dante.

And the worst part, the part that should have terrified me, that should have sent me running to a therapist or a priest or anyone who could help me understand what I was becoming, was that I didn't want to choose.

I wanted both.

I wanted the house on Maple Street and the mattress on the floor, the sourdough and the cigarettes, the man who loved me and the man who ruined me. I was both of those women.

The PowerPoint had transitions, each slide whooshing in from the side with a soft *click* of his laptop trackpad. Ethan had dimmed the lights in the living room, set up his computer on the coffee table, and positioned me on the couch like I was about to receive a quarterly earnings report.

"Okay," he said, rubbing his hands together. "I know this might seem a little extra, but I really wanted to visualize everything. So we're on the same page."

"You made a presentation."

"I made a presentation." He grinned, sheepish and proud. "Just hear me out."

The title slide appeared: Ethan & Vanessa: A Five-Year Plan in elegant serif font, with a photo of us from last fall's apple picking trip. My smile in the picture looked real. I remembered taking it. I remembered thinking, *This is enough. This is good.*

That was four months ago, before a flyer in an arts council newsletter, before a man with tattoos and calloused fingers looked at me like I was starving.

"So," Ethan said, clicking to the next slide. "Year one."

A timeline appeared. Engagement (spring), wedding (fall), honeymoon (Italy, he'd circled it with a little heart), move into the house on Maple Street (winter).

"I figured we'd need a few months after the wedding to settle in before we start thinking about the next phase," he said. "But the house should be ready by December if we close this summer."

"That's... thorough."

"Wait, it gets better."

Slide three: Year Two - Settling In. A stock photo of a couple painting a nursery, beneath it, bullet points: *Establish savings. Vanessa's blog expansion (studio space in the shed?). Begin trying for Baby #1.*

"I did some research," Ethan said, "and apparently it can take six months to a year, so I figured if we start trying when you're twenty-five, we'd have a good window..."

My phone buzzed in my lap. I glanced down. The screen glowed against my thigh, hidden from Ethan's view by the coffee table.

Sarahh: *What are you doing*

Dante, texting at 8 p.m. on a Wednesday. He never texted on Wednesdays. Wednesdays were supposed to be safe.

I typed back quickly, one-handed: *Ethan is showing me a PowerPoint about our future*

"...and by twenty-seven, ideally, we'd have the first one," Ethan was saying. "Which brings us to year three."

The slide changed. Year Three - Baby #1. A stock photo of a woman holding an infant, looking serene and fulfilled in a way that made my stomach turn.

My phone buzzed again.

Sarahh: *A what*

A PowerPoint. With slides. And a timeline.

Sarahh: *You're joking*

I wish I was

"Ness? You with me?"

I looked up. Ethan was watching me, eyebrows raised, the laptop casting blue light across his earnest face.

"Sorry," I said. "Just, taking it all in."

"I know it's a lot." He smiled, soft and understanding. "But I want you to see where we're headed. I want you to know I've thought about this. About us. About everything."

"I can see that."

"Okay, so year three..." He clicked forward. ", first baby. I've already looked into parental leave policies at my company, and they're pretty generous. Three months for both parents, so I could be home with you for the first stretch."

"That's great."

"And then year four..."

Slide five: Year Four - Stability. A photo of a smiling family at a picnic table, bullet points: *Return to work. Childcare research. Begin discussing Baby #2.*

"...we'd have a routine established. You could still do the blog from home, honestly, I think mommy-blogger content could really expand your audience, and by the time Baby #2 comes..."

My phone buzzed.

Sarahh: *How are you sitting through this*

I typed under the table, not looking down, trusting my thumbs to find the right letters: *I don't know. This is insane.*

Ethan clicked to the next slide. Year Five - Baby #2. Another stock photo, this one a pregnant woman laughing in a sunlit kitchen while a toddler tugged at her dress.

"By twenty-nine, ideally," he said. "That gives us good spacing between the kids, not too close, not too far, and we'd still be young enough to enjoy them, travel with them when they're older, show them the world."

The world, I thought. *The world that smells like Dante's cigarettes and cedar and the back hallway of a dive bar.*

My phone buzzed.

Sarahh: *So leave him*

I stared at the words.

Three of them, simple and devastating, like it was easy, like I could just stand up and walk out the door and burn everything I'd built for the past seven years, the relationship, the blog, the life that looked so perfect in photographs.

I can't, I typed.

Sent.

"...and I know it's ambitious," Ethan was saying, clicking to the final slide. Our Beautiful Future in gold script, over a photo of a house that looked suspiciously like the one on Maple Street. "But I really think we can do this, Ness. I think we can have everything."

My phone stayed silent.

Dante didn't respond.

"So?" Ethan closed the laptop, turned to face me, his eyes bright with hope. "What do you think?"

I thought about the mattress on the floor, the taste of whiskey on his tongue. The way he said *good girl* like it meant something filthy and sacred

at the same time.

I thought about the ring in the velvet box at Harrington's, waiting for me to claim it.

I thought about the woman in the stock photos, serene, fulfilled, holding babies in sunlit kitchens, and how I didn't recognize her at all.

"Vanessa?" Ethan's voice softened. He reached for my hand. "Hey. Are you okay?"

I looked up.

His face was so open, so trusting. He had no idea, not about Dante, not about the texts, not about the version of me that came alive in the dark. He saw the woman he'd loved since high school. The woman who baked sourdough and photographed autumn tablescapes and fit perfectly into his five-year plan.

I couldn't tell him the truth. But I couldn't leave, either.

So I did what I'd been doing for weeks. I smiled.

"I'm fine," I said, squeezing his hand. "I'm just..." I blinked, and to my surprise, actual tears pricked at my eyes, not from sadness, from something else. "I'm just so emotional about our beautiful future."

Ethan's whole face lit up.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

He pulled me into a hug, his arms warm and familiar around me, and I let him. I pressed my face into his shoulder and closed my eyes and felt my phone sitting heavy in my lap, Dante's silence louder than anything Ethan had said.

So leave him.

I can't.

I couldn't leave Ethan. He was safety and stability and wealth and security. I couldn't stop seeing Dante. He was excitement, heat, chaos... and not capable of a relationship. I could be the woman in the PowerPoint and the woman on the mattress at the same time.

The ring was heavy on my finger.

Not physically, it was platinum, delicate, the art deco setting Patricia had pushed for because *it photographs so beautifully, dear*, but in every other way that mattered. I felt it constantly. When I raised my champagne glass. When I hugged Ethan's aunts. When I smiled for the pictures his cousin kept taking, documenting this perfect moment for posterity.

The engagement party was at the Hartley family home, a sprawling colonial in the nicest part of town, all white columns and manicured hedges and a backyard that could comfortably hold the sixty-three people who'd come to celebrate our love. There were fairy lights strung through the trees. A string quartet playing softly on the patio. A three-tiered cake that Patricia had ordered from the same bakery that would do our wedding.

Everything was exactly as it should be.

"Vanessa, sweetheart!" Ethan's grandmother, the original owner of my ring, pulled me into a papery embrace. She smelled like lavender and old money. "Let me see it on you. Oh, it's perfect. I always knew it would find the right girl."

"Thank you, Mrs. Hartley."

"Call me Grandma now, dear. You're family."

Family. The word lodged somewhere in my throat.

My own parents were here too, standing near the bar, looking slightly overwhelmed by the Hartley abundance. My mother kept touching the pearl necklace she'd worn to impress Patricia, her nicest piece, a gift from my father for their twentieth anniversary, and my father kept checking his watch like he wasn't sure how long this kind of thing was supposed to last.

"Mom," I said, making my way over to them. "You okay?"

"Oh, honey." She pulled me into a hug, and I smelled her familiar perfume, drugstore vanilla, nothing like Patricia's Chanel, and for a moment I wanted to cry. "We're so proud of you. Ethan's wonderful. This whole family is wonderful. You're going to be so happy."

"Thanks, Mom."

"Your grandmother would have loved to see this." Her eyes welled up. "She always said you'd find a good one."

I thought about my grandmother, Dorothy, the sourdough starter she'd passed down, the way she'd looked at my grandfather, even after fifty years, not with passion, but with something steadier, contentment, peace.

I'd never felt that with Ethan.

I'd never felt anything steadier than a slow, comfortable drift.

"Ness!" Ethan appeared at my elbow, slightly flushed from champagne and happiness. "Come on, my dad wants to do the toast."

"Already?"

"He's been practicing all week. You know how he is."

I let him lead me to the center of the patio, where his father stood with a microphone, an actual microphone, because of course the Hartleys had outdoor audio equipment for occasions like this. The string quartet fell silent. The crowd turned to face us.

"Ladies and gentlemen," Mr. Hartley began, his voice booming and confident, "thank you all for being here tonight to celebrate my son and his beautiful bride-to-be."

Applause, camera flashes. Ethan's hand warm and steady on the small of my back.

"When Ethan first brought Vanessa home," his father continued, "I knew she was special. She was kind. She was gracious. And most importantly, she made my son smile in a way I'd never seen before."

Ethan squeezed my waist.

"Over the years, we've watched their love grow, from high school sweethearts to college long-distance to building a life together. And now, as they take this next step..."

My phone buzzed in my clutch.

I ignored it.

"...I couldn't be more proud. Vanessa, welcome to the family. We are so lucky to have you."

More applause, Mr. Hartley raised his glass. "To Ethan and Vanessa!"

"To Ethan and Vanessa!" the crowd echoed.

I raised my champagne, smiled, drank.

My phone buzzed again.

"Speech!" someone shouted, one of Ethan's fraternity brothers, already drunk. "Speech from the happy couple!"

Ethan laughed and took the microphone from his father. "Alright, alright. I'll keep it short, I promise."

He turned to face me, and his eyes were so full of love that I felt physically sick.

"Vanessa," he said, "I've known since we were seventeen that you were the one. And every day since then, you've made me more certain. You're my best friend, my partner, my future wife." His voice cracked slightly. "I can't wait to spend the rest of my life making you as happy as you make me."

The crowd *awwed*. My mother dabbed at her eyes. Patricia nodded approvingly.

Ethan handed me the microphone.

"Your turn," he said softly.

I looked at the sea of faces. His family, my family, friends from college and high school and work. All of them waiting for me to say something beautiful about the man I was going to marry.

"I..." My voice came out thin. I cleared my throat. "I don't know what to say that Ethan hasn't already said better. He's always been the one with words."

Polite laughter.

"But I do know that I'm so grateful. For all of you. For this family. For..." I looked at Ethan, his hopeful, trusting face. "For this beautiful life we're building together."

I handed the microphone back before anyone could ask for more.

"Perfect," Ethan murmured, kissing my temple. "You're perfect."

My phone buzzed a third time.

"Excuse me," I said. "I need some air."

The driveway was quiet.

I walked past the rows of luxury cars, BMWs and Lexuses and one ostentatious Tesla that belonged to Ethan's uncle, until I was far enough from the party that the string quartet sounded like a distant memory. The fairy lights were just a glow behind me. The night air was cold and sharp.

I opened my clutch, pulled out my phone.

Three messages from Sarahh.

Where are you.

You didn't tell me you had something tonight.

Vanessa.

Just my name, no question mark. Dante never asked questions he didn't want the answer to.

I typed back: *Engagement party.*

The response came in seconds: *Whose Mine.*

A long pause, the three dots appeared, disappeared, appeared again.

Come over.

I stared at the screen.

Behind me, I could hear the party continuing, laughter, the clink of glasses, Patricia's voice rising above the crowd as she directed someone toward the cake table. Inside that house, sixty-three people were celebrating

my future with Ethan. My parents were proud. His grandmother had given me her ring. Everything was exactly as it should be.

And I was standing in the driveway, texting another man.

I'll be late, I typed.

I want to see you.

Why?

The three dots again, then: *Because you're mine.*

My heart stuttered.

He'd never said anything like that before, never claimed me, never suggested that whatever we had was more than just Thursday nights and Saturday escapes. He was supposed to be the uncomplicated part, the thing I could have without consequence, without commitment, without the weight of family heirlooms and five-year plans.

But now he was using words like *mine*.

And I was standing in the driveway of my future in-laws' house, wearing the ring I'd agreed to wear, belonging to everyone and no one at the same time.

I looked down at my hand.

The diamond caught the moonlight, grandmother Hartley's ring, sixty-three years of history on my finger.

I thought about Dante's apartment, the mattress on the floor, the way he looked at me when I walked through his door, not like I was precious or fragile, but like I was something wild he'd caught and didn't intend to release.

I thought about Ethan's PowerPoint. Baby #1 at twenty-seven. Baby #2 at twenty-nine. Our beautiful future, mapped out in slides and bullet points and stock photos of women I didn't recognize.

I thought about the choice.

Ethan or Dante, safety or chaos, the life everyone expected or the one that made me feel alive.

I had to choose, I knew I had to choose.

But not tonight.

Tonight, I was going to go back inside and smile and let Patricia tell me about venue options. I was going to let Ethan hold my hand and introduce me as his fiancée. I was going to hug my mother and tell my father this wouldn't go too late.

And then I was going to drive across town to a studio apartment above a laundromat.

And I was going to let Dante fuck my ever living brains out while wearing Ethan's grandmother's ring.

I typed back: *I'll be there by midnight.*

The string quartet started a new song, something classical and elegant, the kind of music that played at weddings and funerals and all the moments that were supposed to mean something.

I dropped the phone back into my clutch and walked toward the fairy lights.

The choice was already made when he tried to lay claim to me, when he said *You're mine*. It would be my last visit with him.

But there are other bars...